

## **A Comparative Analysis: Christ-like Leadership and Conventional Workplace Leadership**

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Within the current landscape of industrial-organizational psychology, the modern workplace is rampant with executive burnout, toxic culture within corporations, and structural trust issues (Mooijman et al., 2019). Traditional management models often fail to produce healthy organizational operations, thus prompting a search for authentic leadership within organizational development. A healthier management model is found with an authentic leader with ethical conduct and interpersonal awareness. The ideal for secular leadership includes a strong moral compass, emotional intelligence allowing for them to be receptive of others' emotional needs, and objective decisiveness from a balanced viewpoint (Avolio et al., 2004; Gardner et al., 2011). With authentic leadership as the ideal, foundational trust within the organization is requisite. When trust and status instability are present, leadership struggles to balance personal and organizational development, leading to stress and burnout in subordinates (Conger, 2003).

When leadership is threatened by talented subordinates or corporate crises, conventional workplace management falls into organizational disarray. Industrial-organizational studies have found consensus, when conventional managers are placed in an environment of unstable power roles, their behavior shifts to skepticism, anxiety, and lacking trust with their subordinates (Mooijman et al., 2019; Tepper, 2000). The fear of losing status correlates with psychological flaws like groupthink, where leadership ignores advisory council and surrounds themselves with yes-men. Historical failures in corporate leadership include Steve Jobs' destructive favoritism that harmed Apple's employee morale and Edwin Land's costly vanity trip at Polaroid (Conger, 2003). These examples demonstrate the fallout of self-serving conventional leadership that

inhibits organizational growth and increases employee dissatisfaction, burnout, and turnover rates.

To contrast the often-destructive leadership found in conventional management, a faith-centered paradigm demonstrates resilience to workplace stressors and high trust in subordinates (Bleeker et al., 2024; Nsiah, 2013). A Christ-like leader's conduct is focused on Jesus Christ's leadership as found in biblical accounts. This leadership style reverses traditional power dynamics, demonstrating a willingness to get their hands dirty and prioritize the needs of their team over their own. It is an other-focused approach to leadership, otherwise known as a servant-leader. A faith-based servant leader is accountable before God (Nsiah, 2013), remaining calm in the midst of workplace stressors, and is immune to the status anxiety of their conventional counterparts (Cortez, 2023).

Christ-like leadership or servant leadership is a distinctive paradigm in the realm of industrial-organizational psychology, demanding more of organizational leadership. A Christ-like leader is willing to work alongside and serve their subordinates, while allowing their faith to guide their moral actions (Darden, 2006). The vertical connection to deity as a behavioral motivator is very different from that of a conventional leader, whose connection to horizontal status—or egoism—is their driving motivation. A conventional leader may undermine their subordinates, inhibiting organizational growth, while a Christ-like leader will build up their team members, creating a workplace of growth and development. The purpose of this literature review is to demonstrate the effectiveness of a Christ-like leader in comparison to two conventional models: anxiously unstable and abusive management, and authentic leadership.

### **Conceptual Foundations of Authentic and Ethical Leadership**

Gardner and colleagues (2011) seek to define the construct of authentic leadership that has been the subject of much interest in organizations. Rather than self-interested domineering, an authentic leader can be objective in decision-making by balancing opposing viewpoints (Avolio et al., 2004). The attitude of an authentic leader is reflected in their internal moral compass—a seeking to do good in their organization and the people within. An authentic leader is someone who can exhibit self-awareness, leading and communicating with transparency of strengths and weaknesses, building trust and relational transparency in the process.

In modern organizational settings, relational transparency helps to reduce employee turnover by acknowledging executive operational limits, fostering interpersonal honesty and safety (Gardner et al., 2011). When a manager can openly acknowledge their limitations within the organization, subordinates feel secure reporting errors due to the culture of psychological safety run by relational transparency. This openness in communication is what mitigates role ambiguity for subordinates (Avolio et al., 2004), as feedback from leadership is shared without an executive's ego getting in the way. This key structure of authentic leadership is what builds structural trust in an organization, constructing a collaborative partnership in team members.

### **Internal Motivators: Ethical Frameworks Versus Spiritual Purpose**

Vulnerability, hope, and trust are the internal drivers of an authentic leader. Authentic leaders express vulnerability with their teams, showing who they really are, and they are not out to manipulate corporations to their own self-serving designs. An authentic leader is one who can grow the organization through effective ethical management and moral conduct due to their internalized moral compass (Avolio et al., 2004).

While authentic leaders are driven by their internal convictions, a Christ-like servant leader will be motivated by his connection to deity and the convictions of a disciple. A Christ-

like leader is driven by this higher purpose, seeking after God in private and in practice. Being accountable before God is highlighted as crucial for leaders because all will stand before Christ and be accountable unto Him (Cortez, 2023). Therefore, a Christian leader would not destroy their character by bending to short-term profit schemes, personal gains in status, or political convenience (Bleeker et al., 2024). A moral conviction rooted in the divine is founded on principles of righteousness rather than moral relativism.

### **Authentic Leadership and the Moral Compass**

An authentic leader's decision-making process is driven by their internal moral compass. This framework is regulated by the self, strong emotional intelligence and an ethical perspective. Their information processing is balanced, they can look at multiple viewpoints and gather in the best formation of constructs (Avolio et al., 2004). The outward actions of authentic leadership are aligned with their internal ethical convictions and share a focus on the collective good (Gardner et al., 2011). The leader remains accountable to reality rather than personal self-interest.

### **Christian Motivation and the Secure Anchor**

A leader who believes they are accountable to God possesses a moral and ethical anchor to Him. The leader's actions are guided by a Master Exemplar in leadership and righteousness (Nsiah, 2013). Driven by a higher purpose, they seek the counsel of the Divine even in traditional work environments. According to Darden (2006), a Christ-like leader's vision for the organization allows them to communicate that vision through compassionate care and service. This Christian leadership seeks to replicate the leadership of Jesus Christ as found in holy writ. It is a leadership of love and growth; care and servitude are felt by team members and subordinates

(Bleeker et al., 2024), fostering an environment of interpersonal and organizational growth superior to conventional leadership.

### **The Conventional Paradigm: Status Anxiety and Distrust**

Within contemporary industrial-organizational literature, interpersonal trust is recognized as a foundational determinant of organizational success. However, when operating under conditions of unstable status, many leaders decline extending trust to their subordinates, crumbling the very framework requisite for organizational growth. These status-oriented leaders overwhelm and overshadow both their subordinates and the ideals of the company for personal gain. While self-serving biases are typical of managers rising through the ranks, and promotions are often based on charisma and organizational vision, those same traits can undermine employees when possessed by an anxious leader. Driven by ego-protection, anxious managers engage in manipulation of organizational data and filtering reality to build themselves up (Conger, 2003). This in turn heightens their anxiety about losing status, transforming these self-protective and defensive behaviors into their default operational behaviors.

This exact psychological instability was put to the test by Mooijman and colleagues (2019), who placed people in stable or unstable power roles and gauged their trust levels during cooperative games. They found that the more unstable the achievement of power was—even when determined by a coin flip—the more distrusting the leaders became. Ultimately, leaders driven by fear are significantly more likely to operate with systemic distrust, which directly harms an organization's cohesion and growth.

The toll of this power instability is weighty. Managers experience psychological exhaustion when they spend their workday in structural defense against their own team. When an executive views leadership through the lens of unstable horizontal status, even a talented

employee is transformed from an asset into a direct threat (Mooijman et al., 2019). This climate of constant hyper-vigilance creates a structural barrier to innovation, as subordinates withhold creative solutions to avoid triggering the manager's status anxiety. Left unchecked, this anxiety escalates to the point where conventional managers threatened by talented subordinates or corporate crises deploy aggression tactics to protect their hierarchy (Tepper, 2000). An abusive supervisor will resort to public humiliation and theft of innovative credit to prevent promising employees from rising through the ranks and threatening that manager's executive status. Ultimately, organizations that fail to eradicate such status-driven leadership behaviors are much more likely to fail when external forces like the economic pressures of COVID-19 hit (Bleeker et al., 2024).

### **Executive Flaws and Abusive Supervision**

A tragedy of conventional leadership is its vulnerability to psychological flaws like cognitive dissonance and groupthink (Conger, 2003). While a charismatic, ego-driven corporate warrior may hold a compelling vision, that charisma often acts as a double-edged sword in leadership positions. In conventional spheres, insecure leaders surround themselves with “yes-men” and completely ignore advisory council. Concurrently, abusive supervision manifests as a psychological warfare phenomenon when insecure leaders wage an anxiety-driven campaign against their own subordinates (Tepper, 2000). Anyone who threatens their status or egos is ostracized or humiliated—a highly anxious defense mechanism that undermines employees and inhibits organizational growth. At its worst, it comprises downward hostility as a defense for ego. Executives with gifts of communication tend to exaggerate their personal achievements, surround themselves with yes-people, and hide negative organizational statistics behind charming anecdotes.

## **Secular Leadership Fallout**

These leadership flaws are clearly manifested in historical corporate failures. A textbook example of executive cognitive dissonance is found in Edwin Land. Land drove Polaroid to invest half a billion dollars into the Polaroid SX-70 camera because of his vain visions of creating a masterpiece (Conger, 2003). His inflated sense of what consumers wanted led him to ignore corporate data and the product he invested millions into ultimately failed. He ignored realities of the market as a warning against his invention and rather took it as a threat to his intelligence. His domineering attitude led him to ignore the advice of his advisory council, leaving his subordinates walked over and completely devalued in wake of his vanity.

This structural blindness is demonstrated in the actions of Robert Campeau, who used high-interest bonds to purchase huge retail chains. His blind ambition was not impervious to his ignorance of the retail market, and the company he purchased (Allied and Federated Department Stores) went bankrupt under his leadership. Campeau, in an effort to build an empire and anxious about his status, bulldozed any questions of his retail competence or his strategic oversight (Conger, 2003). His management style forced his subordinates to operate in a financially precarious situation, the structural instability of the organization ultimately collapsing under bankruptcy.

Behaviors to preserve ego also drive intellectual theft, as seen with John DeLorean, who was notorious for stealing the invention credit, like the Pontiac GTO, from his colleagues. Worse still, he would deliberately remove people with contrasting opinions from the corporate board. His self-interested decision-making choked out talented employees who had the credit of their inventions stolen right out from under them. Furthermore, many conventional leaders construct competition within their own organizations, creating an “us vs them” environment, serving up a



breeding ground for toxic favoritism (Conger, 2003). Steve Jobs at Apple built up his Macintosh division while aggressively putting down his Apple II division, calling them untalented, clumsy, and outdated. This self-interested leadership ruined Apple's company morale, proving that the psychological safety required from leadership to foster interpersonal and employee growth can be snuffed out under toxic management. When executive stability wavers, destructive behaviors manifest rapidly. This looks like public humiliation, taking credit for another's work, and the silent treatment (Tepper, 2000).

### **Behavioral Manifestations of the Servant Paradigm**

In absolute behavioral contrast, servant leadership is defined as a focus on putting others first. A leader who demonstrates willingness to sacrifice creates a sense of community and collaboration in organizations (Nsiah, 2013). This key aspect of servant leadership, interpersonal awareness, is what makes servant leaders stand apart; the ability to react appropriately to the needs of others, exhibiting empathy and understanding.

This shows a stark contrast to the typical view of a leader where most expect their leadership to be honored by their subordinates and be entreated by their subordinates. This is not the case with the story of Jesus washing His disciples' feet, where He reversed the role and effectively became the servant (Darden, 2006). Jesus Christ demonstrated working alongside His subordinates, teaching them as He went. A servant leader is inherently a teacher, one who can demonstrate appropriate communication and procedural factors.

This exemplifies the attitude leaders should take, voluntarily "getting their hands dirty" and doing the menial tasks they expect their subordinates to accomplish (Darden, 2006). A good servant leader is one willing to do the less desirable tasks and demonstrate the correct way to those working under them. They can delegate responsibilities appropriately, having first depicted

a correct manner of procedure, in the process responding with compassion. Furthermore, Nsiah (2013) highlights prayer as a necessary coping skill for leaders who are placed in high-stress environments; they can slow down and process their environment in a calm manner.

By utilizing internal, meditative practices such as prayer, the Christ-like leader regulates their emotional response to organizational stress instead of projecting anxiety onto their subordinates. The stress management of a disciple leader prevents executive stress from trickling through the organization, allowing the manager to be in-tune with the emotional needs of their team over their own (Nsiah, 2013). Contrastingly, the conventional leader's defense mechanism is manifested as the hostility towards team members.

### **Organizational Outcomes: Failure vs. Resilience**

Tepper (2000) proves that such aggressive psychological warfare is the downfall of many organizations. The reaction within an organization plagued by insecure leadership is devastating, as employees working under this abusive supervision are more likely to have worse productivity, burnout, and higher rates of turnover. Anyone suffering under highly critical and demeaning leadership is likely to poorly perform and search for alternative employment.

Conversely, alternative paradigms offer protective structural buffers. Bleeker, Barkhuizen, and De Braine (2024) looked at how Christian-based leadership contributed to business continuation during COVID-19. They found that organizations benefitted greatly from leaders who could provide strong purpose, good communication, and access to resources. Christian leaders are most likely to promote organizational resilience and put their employee's emotional stability first (Bleeker et al., 2024). This faith-based leadership approach most often results in servant leadership, seeking their subordinate's development and meeting their emotional needs.

## **Conclusion**

The fundamental divergence between a faith-based leader and a conventional one ultimately lies in their underlying purpose and core motivation. A Christ-like leader is motivated by God and their relationship with the Divine. That relationship is manifested in their organizational behaviors, being other-focused, prayerful, and emotionally resilient (Nsiah, 2013). This paradigm depicts a servant leader deeply in tune with their subordinates, delegating tasks according to an intimate knowledge of their team's strengths. They are loyal to their organization and their community, fostering a collaborative environment, loyalty and communal service (Cortez, 2023).

A conventional leader in contrast, is often self-serving and status driven. Their ego-driven actions overwhelm their subordinates and the structure of the organization. The abuses suffered under an executive driven by status-anxiety and organizational instability leads to high employee turnover rates and burnout (Tepper, 2000). A leader driven by fear and suspicion harms organizational growth, projects anxiety, and undermines the potential of their subordinates (Conger, 2003; Mooijman et al., 2019).

The secular corporate world is not entirely devoid of healthy leadership examples. Avolio and colleagues (2004) share that an authentic leader can help organizational growth through their balanced decision making according to ethical conduct. A leader who is guided by their internal moral compass is the best secular leadership model (Gardner et al., 2011). However, even the best example of leadership in the secular realm pales in comparison to a Christian leader whose vertical alignment to God leaves them accountable not to their internal principles but to divine principles (Cortez, 2023). A leader who voluntarily sacrifices for their subordinates because they serve a Higher Being is superior to even an authentic leader.

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